

Outdoor Columbus — 15 Experiences Under \$15 Each

Outstanding outdoor moments in and around Columbus without spending much. Each pick is free or caps at about \$15 per person for the core experience (parking meters and snacks extra).

How to use

1. Pick **one** experience for a free afternoon — or chain two nearby.
2. Check hours/alerts the morning of (flooding, trail closures, heat).
3. Bring water, bug spray in summer, and a layer year-round.

Price key: Free · \$ · \$\$ (still ≤ \$15 for the listed experience)

The 15

1. Highbanks Metro Park — overlook + river trails — Free

Bluff views over the Olentangy, oak forests, and enough loop options for 45–120 minutes.

Go for: golden hour at the overlook.

Tip: Start at the nature center lot; stay on marked trails near edges.

2. Battelle Darby Creek Metro Park — prairie + bison overlook — Free

Wide sky, tallgrass, and (when present) bison viewing from designated areas.

Go for: late spring wildflowers or fall color.

Tip: Pair a short prairie walk with the creek corridor if energy remains.

3. Scioto Mile / downtown riverfront walk — Free

Wide paths, fountains, bridges, and skyline without a ticket.

Go for: sunset from the river steps.

Tip: Park once south of downtown or rideshare in; walk north along the water.

4. Sharon Woods Metro Park — lake loop — Free

Easy multi-use loop around the lake; ducks, shade, and a reset after a long week.

Go for: morning walk before it warms up.

Tip: Bring binoculars for water birds; keep dogs leashed.

5. Inniswood Metro Gardens — seasonal gardens — Free / \$

Woodland gardens, themed beds, and quiet paths inside Westerville's metro system.

Go for: spring blooms or fall foliage.

Tip: Confirm any special-event pricing; everyday garden stroll is typically free/low.

6. Franklin Park Conservatory exterior gardens + park grounds — \$-\$\$

You can enjoy surrounding park space and often catch exterior beauty without a full indoor ticket — or buy timed entry when you want the glasshouse (watch for deals under \$15).

Go for: cherry blossoms / lights seasons when priced in budget.

Tip: Check current gate price the morning of; walk the park loops either way.

7. Griggs Reservoir / riverside path — Free

Water, boats, and a simple paved stretch for legs and lungs.

Go for: weekday late afternoon.

Tip: Watch for cyclists; use marked access points.

8. Three Creeks Metro Park — confluence trails — Free

Where creeks meet — flat trails, birds, and “you’re still in the city” surprise.

Go for: after rain (careful of mud) when water is lively.

Tip: Waterproof shoes if the towpath is wet.

9. Blendon Woods Metro Park — forest + bird blind — Free

Mature woods and a bird-watching blind when you want quiet over spectacle.

Go for: migration seasons (spring/fall mornings).

Tip: Move slowly near the blind; silence pays off.

10. Glacier Ridge Metro Park — open fields + wind — Free

Big-sky metro park northwest of town — meadows, paths, and room to breathe.

Go for: kite weather or clear winter days.

Tip: Little shade — sunscreen and water are not optional in summer.

11. Antrim Park — lake loop (Worthington edge) — Free

Neighborhood-scale nature: lake circuit, geese, and an easy “I only have 40 minutes” win.

Go for: lunch-break loop.

Tip: Crowded after work — go early if you want calm.

12. Blacklick Woods Metro Park — Beech-Maple trails — Free

Classic central Ohio forest floor — roots, canopy, and mushroom season curiosity (look, don’t pick unless you’re trained).

Go for: after a rain when the woods smell alive.

Tip: Trails can be slick; wear grip shoes.

13. Hoover Reservoir — shoreline walk / birding — Free

Water + open light on the northeast side; herons and weekend fishermen energy.

Go for: sunrise if you can swing it.

Tip: Multiple access points — pick one and don’t try the whole reservoir in one go.

14. Hayden Falls — short gorge payoff — Free

A quick walk to a local waterfall pocket when you want “nature drama” without a long drive.

Go for: after steady rain (stronger flow).

Tip: Stairs/terrain — not a stroller stroll; keep kids close.

15. Olentangy Trail segment (north) — Free

Long paved trail for bikes or a purposeful walk under trees along the river corridor.

Go for: a 5-mile out-and-back from a single parking pin.

Tip: Screenshot your start pin; the trail looks similar for miles.

Weekend sampler menus

Mood	Pick 2-3
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Big views	Highbanks + Scioto Mile
Prairie + water	Battelle Darby + Griggs
Quiet woods	Blendon Woods + Blacklick Woods
Easy loops	Sharon Woods + Antrim
Birds	Blendon blind + Hoover Reservoir

Under-\$15 budget worksheet

Item	Planned \$	Actual \$
Entry / ticket (if any)		
Parking / meter		
Coffee / snack		
Misc		
Total (keep ≤ \$15 for "experience")		

Gear checklist (all seasons)

- ☐ Water
- ☐ Phone offline map / screenshot of lot
- ☐ Comfortable shoes with grip
- ☐ Bug spray (May–September)
- ☐ Rain shell or sun hat
- ☐ Small trash bag (pack out)
- ☐ Optional: binoculars, picnic blanket

Weather / season swaps

Condition	Do this
Heat advisory	Shade parks early (Blendon, Blacklick); skip open prairie midday
Ice / freeze-thaw	Stick to paved Scioto Mile / Antrim; avoid gorge stairs
Flooding	Skip creek-bottom trails; choose overlooks (Highbanks)
Peak fall weekends	Arrive at opening or pick less famous loops (Glacier Ridge, Three Creeks)

After-trip note

Favorite of the 15: _____

Would bring guests to: _____

Next park to try: _____

Buckeye Trail Guide · Curated by Keith Householder · Columbus, Ohio

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